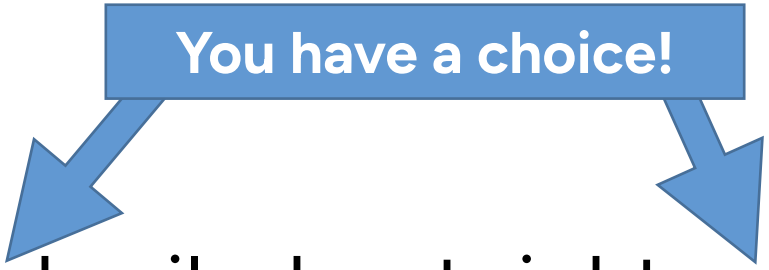
This material is to a large degree created using GenAI. Is that ethical?

Project Carrier Course, Part 1 CM2015

Ethics Introduction

Autumn 2025 - Martin Jacobsson

What is Ethics?



- Ethics is about good and evil, about right and wrong.
- It is about what we as humans should and should not do.
- How we should live our lives.
- (Andersson&Lennerfors 2011, p. 9)

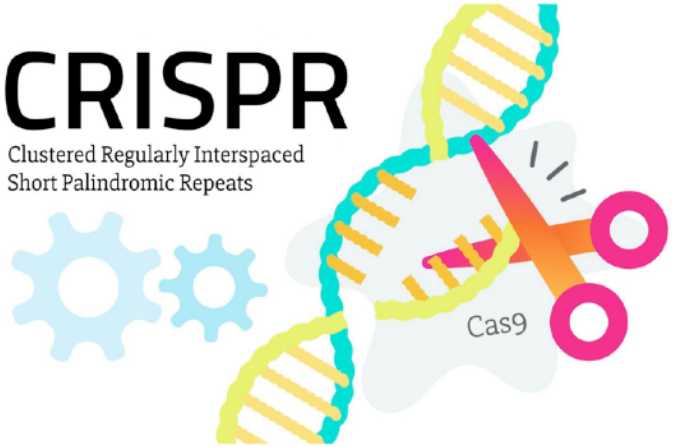
- But also how to get there!

Why Ethics?

Technology and science:

- are essential to our modern society
- influence our values
- can be a tool for most purposes
- have a major impact, both positive and negative, on all of our lives.







Ethical Theories (top three!)



- Consequences (Consequentialism, utilitarianism, …)
  - E.g. maximize happiness and minimize suffering
  - The consequence of an action is what counts
  - Sometimes mathematical approach: quantification, probabilities, …
- Deontological ethics (e.g. Immanuel Kant)
  - Categorical imperative: Act only on principles you'd want everyone to follow universally.
  - Duty over desire: Moral actions stem from duty, not personal gain or feelings.
  - But also human dignity and intention to do what's right
- Virtue ethics (e.g. Aristotle)
  - Aspired character trait: Emphasizes the character of the individual rather than rules (like deontology) or consequences (like utilitarianism).
  - "What kind of person should I be?" rather than "What should I do?"
  - Achieving eudaemonia - human well-being

Normative principles in applied ethics (some)

- **Personal benefit**: acknowledge the extent to which an action produces beneficial consequences for the individual in question.
- **Social benefit**: acknowledge the extent to which an action produces beneficial consequences for society.
- **Principle of benevolence**: help those in need.
- **Principle of paternalism**: assist others in pursuing their best interests when they cannot do so themselves.
- **Principle of harm**: do not harm others.
- **Principle of honesty**: do not deceive others.
- **Principle of lawfulness**: do not violate the law.
- **Principle of autonomy**: acknowledge a person's freedom over his/her actions or physical body.
- **Principle of justice**: acknowledge a person's right to due process, fair compensation for harm done.
- **Rights**: acknowledge a person's rights to life, information, privacy, free expression, and safety.

No single principle resolves all dilemmas. Applied ethics often requires balancing these principles based on context, values, and stakeholder needs.

Tom Beauchamp and James Childress

- Four normative principles in biomedical ethics:
  - Autonomy
  - Beneficence
  - Non-maleficence
  - Justice
- https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=2RjAz-sUQ-U
- https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=w9Uf2NCN5gc

The Declaration of Helsinki

The Declaration of Helsinki is a cornerstone document in medical research ethics, established by the World Medical Association (WMA) in 1964. It is a living document and was last updated in 2024. It provides ethical principles for research involving human subjects, ensuring their protection, dignity, and rights.

Key Principles

1. **Informed Consent**: Participants must give voluntary, informed consent after being fully informed about the study's purpose, risks, and benefits.
2. **Risk-Benefit Balance**: Research must minimize harm and maximize benefits, with risks justified by potential gains.
3. **Vulnerable Populations**: Special protections for vulnerable groups (e.g., children, prisoners, or those unable to consent).
4. **Confidentiality**: Participants' privacy and data must be safeguarded.
5. **Independent Review**: Research protocols must be reviewed by ethics committees.
6. **Right to Withdraw**: Participants can leave a study at any time without penalty.

Impact

The Declaration shapes global research standards, influencing laws, institutional policies, and clinical trials. It emphasizes that the well-being of participants must always outweigh scientific or societal interests.

Ethical Work Process

Göran Collste (Inledning till etiken, Studentlitteratur)

- Problem Formulation
- Information Collection
- Identifying the Alternatives
- Consequence and Action Assessment, for Who? Where? When?
- Probability Assessment
- Valuation
- Decision
- Action
- Evaluation

Now go on and explore these topics using Generative AI!

Ask GenAI to provide new ethical aspects to your project and the other's project too.

Ethical Seminar

- **Preparation**: You should read the ethical section of the two other projects that you have been assigned. You may use GenAI to analyse the ethical sections.

- Active participation, bring laptop for note taking and GenAI.
- In groups of 3-5 students (we divide the groups at the seminar):
  - Discuss each project's ethical analysis
  - Are important aspects missing?
  - Can ethical theories / normative principles guides us?
  - Finally, in bullet form give feedback to all three projects
- You may use GenAI tools here! But don't stop using your own brain!


KTH
VETENSKAP
OCH KONST